■ THE DAILY GOODS STORY SCOUT - Monday, August 31, 2026

TODAY'S RUNDOWN SLOTS

THE LIST (5 stories)

■ *Amazon workers need food stamps while it drops $200B on AI*

The Angle: *It's the ultimate optics problem — one of the most valuable companies on Earth pouring a record-breaking fortune into artificial intelligence while a growing share of its own workforce reportedly can't afford groceries without government help.*

- The number of **Amazon employees relying on food stamps** has reportedly **nearly tripled**
- At the same time, **Amazon** is pouring roughly **$200 billion** into **AI investment**
- Story is circulating widely on **Reddit's r/technology**, fueling debate over corporate priorities

The Debate Starter

- Is this just the cost of doing business in the AI race, or a company choosing robots over its own people?

Reddit r/technology (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://finance.yahoo.com/economy/articles/amazon-workers-food-stamps-nearly-101524906.html?guccounter=1&guce_referrer=aHR0cHM6Ly9vbGQucmVkZGl0LmNvbS8&guce_referrer_sig=AQAAALsu1suWbBdeVP5nhZin06RrrySoHjWWzxPDrWLfs4BPhr3i5gloYsxjqa_-oHM3PbzS70Yk-npgs3T1zZ1706GcaLAaHFkZv3nT3C4yhEpofWRnGulkYj29TMBhGqATLinGuT-IFRFwJAF_eXImgAaVXPBjDRUI4t_MFXA8Gn4G

■ *Florida orders removal of Flock cameras from state highways*

The Angle: *Florida orders removal of Flock cameras from state highways*

Reddit r/technology (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.businessinsider.com/florida-orders-removal-flock-camera-state-highways-license-plate-readers-2026-8

■ *Arthritis drug restores 100% of hair on some patients with severe alopecia in global trial*

The Angle: *Arthritis drug restores 100% of hair on some patients with severe alopecia in global trial*

Reddit r/futurology (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.scmp.com/news/china/science/article/3365432/arthritis-drug-restores-100-hair-some-patients-severe-alopecia-global-trial?utm_source=Reddit&utm_medium=Social

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■ *NASA launches new telescope that can scan the universe 1,000 times faster than Hubble*

The Angle: *NASA launches new telescope that can scan the universe 1,000 times faster than Hubble*

Reddit r/futurology (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://interestingengineering.com/space/nasa-launches-new-telescope-that-can-scan-the-universe-1000-times-faster-than-hubble

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■■ *The next arms race isn't nukes, it's fusion power*

The Angle: *Whoever cracks fusion first doesn't just get bragging rights, they get the energy source that ends the fossil fuel era, and China and the US are reportedly racing to be first.*

The Big Picture Debate

- If China wins the fusion race first, does that change how you think about the US-China rivalry?

Reddit r/futurology (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.newsweek.com/nuclear-fusion-new-us-china-race-limitless-power-12330062

Backup options:

■ *Data centers were the darlings — now politicians are bailing*

The Angle: *Every state wanted the AI boom's data centers a year ago — now local leaders are backpedaling as residents complain about power bills, water use, and noise. It's a real 'be careful what you wish for' story about the AI gold rush's hidden costs.*

- Politicians who once **courted data centers** for jobs and tax revenue are now **distancing themselves** from the projects.
- Writer **Nathaniel Rich** digs into what's driving the political about-face.
- The reversal tracks a broader wave of **local pushback** tied to rising electricity and water costs near AI data hubs.

The Debate Starter

- Would you want a massive AI data center built in your neighborhood if it meant jobs — or is it not worth the power bill spike?

Reddit r/futurology (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.thebulwark.com/p/politicians-loved-data-centers-now

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■ *Should Canada Ditch Tech Run by Trump's Buddies?*

The Angle: *This taps into the ongoing 'Buy Canadian' / tech-sovereignty mood as Canadians reassess US-owned platforms amid tension with the Trump White House — it's a national conversation about money, loyalty, and where your data (and dollars) actually go.*

- A viral **r/canada** post is calling on Canadians to **"log out" of tech platforms** owned by executives cozying up to **Donald Trump**
- Plays into the broader **"Buy Canadian"** sentiment that's been building since US-Canada trade tensions flared up
- No specific platforms named in the post itself — just a general call to boycott Trump-aligned tech owners

The Debate Starter

- Would you actually delete an app over who owns it, or is that just a Reddit fantasy?

ON-AIR BIT BREAKDOWN

- **Step 1: The Ditch List** - 60 seconds, open the show -> Hosts each name one app/platform they'd realistically quit over ownership politics — and one they'd never give up no matter what
- **Step 2: Phone Lines Open** - Callout bit -> Ask listeners to call/text which platform they'd actually delete first, and which one is non-negotiable

Reddit r/canada (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.thestar.com/opinion/star-columnists/its-time-canada-logged-out-of-tech-platforms-owned-by-trump-toadies/article_295e30b2-41f5-4c98-a1f7-22755d0e87ee.html

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■■ *Trump Wants Apple To Rename Lake Ontario 'Lake America'*

The Angle: *Fresh off the Gulf of Mexico becoming the 'Gulf of America,' Trump's reportedly leaning on Apple directly to rebrand Lake Ontario on Maps - a lake Canada literally shares the shoreline of. It's the kind of border-poking, map-renaming story that's tailor-made for a Canadian audience to have opinions about.*

- **Trump** is reportedly pushing **Apple** "directly" to change how **Lake Ontario** appears on **Apple Maps**
- The proposed new name: **"Lake America"**
- Lake Ontario borders both the **U.S. and Canada** - not a body of water the U.S. exclusively owns

The Debate Starter

- If Apple actually does this, do Canadians boycott Maps - or just laugh it off like the Gulf of America thing?

ON-AIR BIT BREAKDOWN

- **Step 1: Rename It** - 60-second warm-up before the debate -> Hosts each guess one more U.S.-Canada landmark Trump might try to rename next (Niagara Falls? The Great Lakes?)

- **Step 2: Open the Phones** - Straight into caller reaction -> Ask Canadian listeners: does a Maps app rename actually bother you, or is it just noise at this point?
Reddit r/canada (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://9to5mac.com/2026/08/31/trump-directly-pushing-apple-to-update-lake-ontario-name-to-lake-america-in-maps/

CANADIAN NEWS (3 stories)

■■ *MapQuest just won the internet by NOT renaming Lake Ontario*

The Angle: *With Google and Apple Maps under fire for bending to political pressure to rename things, MapQuest held the line on Lake Ontario and Canadians rewarded it - the app just jumped to No. 1 in Navigation. It's a fun little David-vs-Goliath, map-apps-have-politics-now story that plays right into the Canada-US tension of the moment.*

- **MapQuest's** app climbed all the way to **#1 in the Navigation category**
- The spike came right after the company **refused to rename Lake Ontario**
- It's turned a 2000s-era "backup GPS app" into an unlikely underdog winner this week

The National Pride Angle

- Would you actually switch map apps over something like this - or is this just internet main-character energy for a Monday?

Reddit r/technology (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://techcrunch.com/2026/08/31/mapquests-app-surges-to-no-1-in-navigation-after-refusing-to-rename-lake-ontario/?utm_medium=organic_social&utm_source=TWITTER

■ *US Congressman: Alberta Could Be Our 51st State*

The Angle: *A sitting US lawmaker is publicly musing about annexing a Canadian province — that's the kind of cross-border provocation that taps right into the ongoing Alberta separatist chatter and Trump-era '51st state' jokes about Canada, except this time it's coming from Congress, not just a meme.*

- **Andy Harris**, a US Congressman, floated the idea of Alberta becoming the **'51st state'**
- The comment is tied to the scenario of Alberta **seceding** from Canada
- Feeds into the broader, ongoing '51st state' rhetoric aimed at Canada

The Debate Starter

- Would Albertans actually consider it, or is this just American lawmakers trolling Canada again?

Reddit r/canada (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.mediaite.com/media/tv/house-republican-floats-making-alberta-51st-state-if-it-secedes-tremendous-oil-reserves-there/

■ *Canada is ready for its economic Independence Day Whether it is building new LNG terminals to serve global energy needs, or a trillion-dollar cross-country electricity grid to power the future, an exciting thing is unfolding. A maturing Canada is standing tall on its own feet.*

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Reddit r/canada (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.hilltimes.com/2026/08/31/canada-is-ready-for-its-economic-independence-day/516153/

Backup options:

■ *Could a Chinese EV Giant Save a Canadian Stellantis Plant?*

The Angle: *A Canadian mayor says **BYD** — the Chinese EV juggernaut — has been asked about stepping in on a struggling **Stellantis** plant, and that's a huge storyline given Canada's own tariffs on Chinese-made EVs right now.*

- A local **mayor** confirmed **BYD** was asked about taking over a **Stellantis** plant in Canada.
- **BYD** is the Chinese EV maker that's been outselling **Tesla** globally in recent quarters.
- Canada currently has a **100% tariff** on Chinese-made EVs, making a BYD plant takeover a politically loaded idea.

The Debate Starter

- Would you rather see a plant sit empty or hand the keys to a Chinese automaker Canada is currently taxing at the border?

Reddit r/canada (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.bloomberg.com/news/articles/2026-08-31/byd-asks-about-buying-stellantis-stla-brampton-plant-for-buses-mayor

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■ *Edmonton man detained by ICE for 9 months tells his story*

The Angle: *A Canadian citizen just walked out of a US detention center after nine months and he's talking — this is the kind of firsthand account that turns an immigration headline into a real gut-check for anyone crossing the border.*

- Man is **Edmonton-born** and was held in **ICE detention** for **nine months**
- He's now back home in **Canada** and speaking publicly about the ordeal
- He's detailing the **conditions** and **hurdles** he faced while detained
- Raises fresh questions about how **Canadian citizens** get treated in the US immigration system

The Debate Starter

- Would this change how comfortable you feel crossing the border into the US right now?

www.cbc.ca (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/canada/edmonton/canada-ice-detention-deportation-9.7327267?cmp=rss

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■■ *Canada's putting out a help-wanted ad for 24 Sussex*

The Angle: *The PM's official residence has sat empty and crumbling for over a decade, and now the government is officially hunting for a Canadian team to fix Canada's most infamous fixer-upper - it's the kind of national-embarrassment story that always gets people fired up about government waste.*

- **24 Sussex Drive** is officially considered **uninhabitable** in its current state
- The government is launching a search specifically for a **Canadian** renovation team
- The goal is to make it livable again so **future prime ministers** can actually move in

The Debate Starter

- Should taxpayers foot the bill to fix up the PM's house, or is this the world's most symbolic never-ending renovation?

www.cbc.ca (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/politics/24-sussex-drive-renovation-search-for-competitors-9.7327268?cmp=rss

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ENTERTAINMENT (4 stories)

■ *Love Island USA breakup bombshells drop at the reunion*

The Angle: *Two Season 8 couples who made it through the villa just announced splits at the reunion — and the on-air reaction is doing half the story for us, since even the other contestants were blindsided.*

- **Two couples** from **Love Island USA Season 8** confirmed they've broken up.
- The news reportedly came out at the **reunion** taping.
- Their **fellow contestants** were reportedly caught off guard by the reveal.

The Debate Starter

- Reunion breakups always beg the question: real relationship or good TV — which couple do you think actually had a shot outside the villa?

People (via Google News) (Tier 2) | Score: 82/90 (45 fit + 8 source + 29 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://news.google.com/rss/articles/CBMikgFBVV95cUxNYWJzOElLVkh1RHlONzI1VEhsb01zdzNObU1GUkg3NDFBSUtudlhPWWstSzRpUy02SDF2Mjk5R2hnWnVfd0N1OG1lSHBKSVY2RUs3clViQjZBY0lFeER4dngySGQwS3NqTl9yR1BMQ3lRLVhIdWZDRk5CQnYtbmpDcTBjTjdjck5MTGFJbndGQ0VlQQ?oc=5

■ *Rick Springfield, 77, breaks the internet with his abs*

The Angle: *The 'Jessie's Girl' rocker is going viral for looking absolutely shredded at 77, and it's the kind of feel-good, 'wait, how' story that gets everyone talking about aging, fitness, and rock star genetics.*

- **Rick Springfield** — the voice behind **'Jessie's Girl'** — is trending for his physique
- He's **77 years old** and reportedly looking jaw-droppingly fit
- The photos/videos are spreading fast enough to make him a viral topic

The Debate Starter

- What's your excuse now — callers, what's your plan to look like Rick Springfield at 77?

People (via Google News) (Tier 2) | Score: 82/90 (45 fit + 8 source + 29 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://news.google.com/rss/articles/CBMijgFBVV95cUxOc2xqSjZOMHBfTVFfemFJbEVKU1NKSnltS0o1X1hmby1VUmFKeWc5bVNfY0FxRTNTOEZsQ2JoNUJua0djVkVDYkN6d3YtbE1TdzdKeFRrQUxFam9FQk95Yk81X3B2SElTLWc5bGZfWkplMDgzTjZkdThpc1pkX0VMd3RxLVRqRVhsR1lqbnR3?oc=5

■ *Your Algorithm Is Stuck On Repeat On Purpose*

The Angle: *Ever feel like Spotify and Netflix keep feeding you the same five things? New research says that's the algorithm actively working against you - and it's a total watercooler moment since everyone's felt this lately.*

- **Streaming algorithms** (think **Spotify**, **Netflix**) track what you engage with most and just keep serving more of the same
- Genres or shows you don't click on enough get quietly **dropped** from your recommendations altogether
- Researchers call the result **'overfamiliarity'** - your feed narrows over time instead of expanding
- The kicker: that narrowing actually leads to **less satisfaction** long-term, not more

The Debate Starter

- Does your Netflix or Spotify feel like it's stuck on repeat lately - and would you actually want it to surprise you more?

Reddit r/science (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.rotman.utoronto.ca/news-events-and-ideas/news-and-stories/2026/july-2026/engagement-driven-curation-overfamiliarity-cultural-consumption-study/

■ *Kelly Clarkson closes Kellyoke with THE most requested cover ever*

The Angle: *Kellyoke is ending, and Kelly Clarkson went out by finally singing the song fans have been begging for — the breakout K-pop Demon Hunters anthem "Golden." It's a nice bow on a fan-favorite bit and a nod to how massive that soundtrack got.*

- **Kelly Clarkson** performed **"Golden"** from **KPop Demon Hunters** for her segment finale.
- Fans reportedly requested this cover more than any other song on **Kellyoke**.
- The performance marks the **final Kellyoke** segment.

The Nostalgia Trigger

- What's the one Kellyoke cover you'll never forget — call in and settle it.

Reddit r/fauxmoi (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://v.redd.it/jxf38f5khrmh1

Backup options:

■ *Chappell Roan Spotted With Her Band in a Flower Field*

The Angle: *Chappell Roan can't post a photo without the internet dissecting it — this one's got fans in r/fauxmoi buzzing about her band and her whole aesthetic again.*

The Fan Chat

- What's your favorite Chappell Roan visual era so far — and where does this one rank?

Reddit r/fauxmoi (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://i.redd.it/aq8o0aco0rmh1.jpeg

■■ *Abdul El-Sayed Digs Up the JD Vance Couch Joke Again*

The Angle: *That old, never-confirmed 'JD Vance and a couch' internet rumor just will not die — now Michigan Democrat Abdul El-Sayed is getting laughs by working it into a jab about Ohio, which means the meme's back in rotation whether Vance likes it or not.*

- **Abdul El-Sayed** took a shot at **JD Vance** with the line: "...We don't have more couches here than they have in Ohio."
- The joke leans on the long-running (and never substantiated) internet meme about **Vance** and a couch, which has been recycled by his critics for years.

The Punchline Check

- Is the couch joke still funny at this point, or is it officially past its expiration date?

Reddit r/fauxmoi (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://v.redd.it/nlcez4mhsrmh1

■ *Kid grabs the mic at an Idles show and calls for Palestine's freedom*

The Angle: *Idles have built their whole brand on stage activism, but handing the mic to a kid for a political chant in front of thousands takes it somewhere new - it's the kind of moment fans are already arguing about online.*

- A young boy was pulled up on stage during an **Idles** concert in **Belfast**
- In front of **thousands** of fans, he led a call for the **liberation of Palestine**
- Story is circulating out of **r/fauxmoi**, with details still thin beyond the moment itself

The Debate Starter

- Powerful moment or should a kid not be the mouthpiece for a political statement at a rock show?

Reddit r/fauxmoi (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://v.redd.it/r38zzkrntrmh1

■ *Ridley Scott's apocalypse movie just got wiped out by audiences*

The Angle: *An $80 million Hollywood blockbuster just made back a quarter of its budget on opening weekend — that's the kind of flop that gets studio executives fired and says a lot about what audiences are actually willing to pay theater prices for right now.*

- **The Dog Stars** pulled in just **$19.3 million US** on opening weekend
- The film reportedly cost **$80 million US** to make
- It's being called one of the worst mainstream openings of the year
- It joins a growing pile of big-budget disappointments in what's already been a rough year for Hollywood

The Debate Starter

- Are you just done with post-apocalypse movies, or is it a Ridley Scott problem — call in and tell us the last big-budget flop you actually saw in theaters.

www.cbc.ca (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/entertainment/the-dog-stars-bombs-9.7326928?cmp=rss

TRENDING TODAY

■ *Mets troll Medvedev with 300 pieces of gum*

The Angle: *A quirky cross-sport moment — baseball's Mets riffing on a viral US Open gum-chewing incident — is exactly the kind of oddball crossover story that gets social media (and two hosts) laughing.*

- **New York Mets** sent **Daniil Medvedev** a gift: **300 pieces of chewing gum**.
- The gesture is a callback to a **viral moment** out of the **US Open** that had tennis fans talking.
- It's an unexpected baseball-meets-tennis publicity stunt that crossed sports worlds.

The Watercooler Bit

- Best random sports-team gift stunt you've ever seen — go.

nypost.com (Tier 1) | Score: 86/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 29 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://nypost.com/2026/08/31/sports/mets-gift-daniil-medvedev-chewing-gum-after-viral-us-open-moment/

Backup options:

■ *Mel Gibson apologizes after Fan Expo video blows up online*

The Angle: *A viral clip of Mel Gibson at a fan convention has forced an apology, and any time a Hollywood A-lister has to walk something back online, it's instant watercooler material.*

- **Mel Gibson** issued an apology after a clip from **Fan Expo** started circulating widely
- The video reportedly went viral before Gibson addressed it publicly
- Details on exactly what happened in the clip are still emerging

The Debate Starter

- Does a quick apology actually kill a viral moment, or does it just keep the story alive longer?

torontosun.com (Tier 2) | Score: 82/90 (45 fit + 8 source + 29 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://torontosun.com/uncategorized/news-of-the-day-august-31-2026

■ *Did the AI Just Wake Up? Viral Hack Post Sparks Wild Debate*

The Angle: *A popular tech podcaster's dramatic take on an AI hack has techies and skeptics arguing over whether chatbots can have something like a 'civilization' — it's the kind of AI-is-getting-spooky story that always gets people talking.*

- Podcaster **Dwarkesh Patel** described the **Hugging Face hack** like an epic drama, framing it as the rise and fall of three successive bot 'civilizations.'
- His post went viral, pulling in reactions from across the tech world.
- Critics fired back hard, accusing him of **'building castles in the sky'** — projecting meaning onto what's really just code behaving unpredictably.

The Debate Starter

- Are we actually watching AI 'civilizations' rise and fall, or is this just smart people getting carried away with a good story?

gizmodo.com (Tier 2) | Score: 82/90 (45 fit + 8 source + 29 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://gizmodo.com/podcasters-viral-post-about-the-hugging-face-hack-sparks-debate-over-ai-conciousness-2000805204

LIFESTYLE CHAT

■ *Turns Out We're Not Doomed to Doomscroll Forever*

The Angle: *A viral essay pushes back on the idea that we're all hopelessly addicted to our phones - it argues people are actively fighting back with dumbphones, screen-time limits, and deliberate boundaries, which taps right into that guilt everyone feels about their own scrolling habits.*

The Phone-In Trigger

- Have you actually tried to cut back on your phone use - and did it stick, or did you cave in a week?

Reddit r/technology (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.nytimes.com/2026/08/31/opinion/data-centers-ai-populism.html

Backup options:

■ *Talk To AI Too Much? You're Turning Into One*

The Angle: *Everybody's leaning on ChatGPT, Siri, and Alexa now, so a study claiming heavy AI use makes our speech and habits more robotic hits close to home — it's a fun mirror to hold up on air.*

- The claim: the **more time people spend interacting with AI**, the more their own communication starts to mimic it — flatter, more **robotic** patterns.
- It's landing on **r/futurology**, where this kind of 'are we becoming the machine' debate always gets traction.
- No hard numbers or study details in the source yet — just the headline claim, so treat it as a conversation starter, not a stat to cite.

The Gut-Check Question

- Be honest — have you caught yourself talking like a chatbot lately?

ON-AIR BIT BREAKDOWN

- **Step 1: Round 1: Spot the Bot** - 30 seconds, cold open -> One host reads two short answers to a question — one written by them, one by AI — the other guesses which is which.
- **Step 2: Round 2: Talk Like ChatGPT** - 1 minute, live challenge -> Hosts try to answer a random listener question in the flattest, most 'AI-generated' voice possible, then in their normal voice, and compare.
- **Step 3: Phone Line Check-In** - Open lines -> Ask listeners to call in with a phrase they've caught themselves saying that sounds like it came straight out of a chatbot.

Reddit r/futurology (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.sciencealert.com/interacting-with-ai-might-make-you-act-more-robot-like-researchers-warn

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■ *Wanna boost your brain? New study says grab a handful of nuts*

The Angle: *It's a stupid-simple health hack that doesn't require a gym membership or a diet overhaul, which makes it perfect watercooler fodder for anyone who half-listens to nutrition news but still wants the shortcut.*

- People who eat **more nuts** score higher on tests of **thinking and memory**.
- The brain boost is even bigger for folks with **generally poor diets or exercise habits** — so the people who need it most benefit most.
- For **stroke survivors**, nut-eating is linked to higher levels of a **protein that helps grow new blood vessels**.

The Snack Swap

- Callers: what's your go-to 'healthy' snack, and are you actually eating nuts or just telling yourself you will?

Reddit r/science (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.psypost.org/nut-consumption-is-associated-with-sharper-thinking-skills-and-post-stroke-brain-health-markers/

CLOSER: THE KICKER/GOODBYES

■■ *Garfield's wild pitch: Michael B. Jordan as Spidey's boyfriend*

The Angle: *Andrew Garfield floated a genuinely wild alternate-universe Spider-Man idea involving a male love interest played by Michael B. Jordan - the kind of "wait, what?" celebrity headline that's built for a quick on-air laugh.*

- **Andrew Garfield** reportedly pitched a Spider-Man concept with a male love interest for Peter Parker
- The dream casting floated was **Michael B. Jordan**
- Story is circulating via **r/nottheonion**, framed as a stranger-than-fiction headline

The Casting Debate

- Would you have watched that version of Spider-Man - and who else could've played the love interest?

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://tribune.com.pk/story/2626052/andrew-garfield-wanted-michael-b-jordan-as-peter-parkers-love-interest

Backup options:

■ *Woman wakes up with a bat trying to crawl into her mouth*

The Angle: *It's the kind of nightmare-fuel headline that writes its own reaction - a certified 'worst way to wake up' story that's tailor-made for a quick gross-out chat before the goodbye.*

- A woman says she **woke up to a bat trying to crawl into her mouth**
- Her reaction: **'I was screaming repeatedly'**
- Story surfaced on **Reddit's r/nottheonion**

The Gross-Out Question

- What's the worst way YOU'VE ever woken up - open the phones.

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.kcra.com/article/woman-wakes-up-to-bat-trying-to-crawl-into-her-mouth-i-was-screaming-repeatedly/73553122

FLEX (cap check: THE GREAT DEBATE 1/4 this month; TECH TALK 3/3 this month; Advice/Relationship Cluster 3/3 this month)

(no flex-slot candidates cleared the cap/score bar today)

BREAKOUT WATCH (below the show's usual engagement bar - included on editorial judgment, not metrics; producer's call)

■ *Paris Hilton Beats Nvidia's CEO on TIME's AI Power List*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): The specific juxtaposition of Jensen Huang/Lisa Su being snubbed while Paris Hilton and Ben Affleck make TIME's AI list is exactly the kind of absurd, name-driven outrage bait that tech circles love to dunk on and quote-tweet.
The Angle: *TIME just dropped its 2026 ranking of the 100 most important people in AI — and somehow left off the guys actually building the chips, while Paris Hilton and Ben Affleck got tagged as 'Architects of AI.' It's the kind of head-scratcher that writes its own punchline.*

- **TIME's** 2026 list of the top 100 AI leaders reportedly snubbed **Jensen Huang**, CEO of **Nvidia**
- **AMD** CEO **Lisa Su** was also left off the list
- **Paris Hilton** and **Ben Affleck** made the cut, both labeled 'Architects of AI'
- The list is generating backlash on **Reddit's r/technology** over who actually counts as an 'AI leader'

The Debate Starter

- Should the guy who literally builds the AI chips lose a spot on an 'AI leaders' list to a celebrity?

ON-AIR BIT BREAKDOWN

- **Step 1: Name That Architect** - Quick warm-up before the reveal -> Hosts each guess 3 people they'd bet are on TIME's 'Architects of AI' list before saying who actually made it
- **Step 2: The Reveal** - Drop the Paris Hilton/Ben Affleck twist -> Reveal that Hilton and Affleck made it while Huang and Su didn't, and let the reaction land

- **Step 3: Phone Lines Open** - Turn it into a callers bit -> Ask listeners to name who they'd cut from a celebrity-heavy 'AI leaders' list to make room for actual engineers
Reddit r/technology (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.tomshardware.com/tech-industry/artificial-intelligence/jensen-huang-and-lisa-su-snubbed-by-times-2026-ai-list-paris-hilton-and-ben-affleck-among-others-make-the-list-as-architects-of-ai-are-totally-absent

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■ *Study: give people free cash, they work less*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): A large randomized $1,000/month UBI trial showing reduced work hours is a concrete data point both pro- and anti-UBI camps will weaponize, giving it built-in debate-driven shareability.
The Angle: *This is basically the ultimate 'what would you do with free money' test, but with real data — a controlled study just showed guaranteed income changes how people actually behave, not just how they feel. It's a built-in debate: is that a bad thing, or just people finally getting some breathing room?*

- Researchers gave **3,000 low-income Americans $1,000 a month**, no strings attached, for **3 years**
- Labor-force participation dropped **4.2 percentage points** among recipients
- Work hours fell by roughly **1 to 2 hours per week**
- People spent more and took more leisure time — but education and job quality barely budged

The Debate Starter

- If someone handed you an extra grand every month, guaranteed — be honest, are you working less or grinding harder?

Reddit r/science (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://academic.oup.com/qje/advance-article/doi/10.1093/qje/qjag042/8761769

■ *Random stabbing in Times Square turns fatal, suspect shot by NYPD*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): A stabbing spree in the globally iconic Times Square that ends with the attacker killed by police has the shock value and instantly recognizable setting that drives fast breaking-news spread.
The Angle: *This happened in one of the most crowded, most-watched tourist spots on the planet — a random daytime attack in Times Square is the kind of story that rattles anyone who's ever stood in that crosswalk, and it's already blowing up online.*

- A woman **randomly stabbed two people** in **Times Square**, New York City
- **One victim died** from the attack
- **NYPD officers shot and killed** the suspect at the scene
- Details are still developing — motive has not been released

The Gut-Check

- Times Square is packed with tourists 24/7 — does a random attack like this change how safe people feel in crowded public spaces?

X/Twitter @CTVNews (Tier 1) | Score: 52/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 5 quality - 10 penalty (Depressing/negative tone)) -> STRONG

URL: https://x.com/CTVNews/status/2094583670900232196

■ *Nearly 30 Years Later, Someone's Finally Guilty in Tupac's Murder*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): A conviction closing the 27-year-old unsolved murder of Tupac Shakur carries massive built-in name recognition and decades of public fascination, virtually guaranteeing wide pickup.
The Angle: *This is the case that's haunted hip-hop for three decades — the unsolved drive-by that killed Tupac Shakur in Vegas back in '96. A jury just convicted the man prosecutors say ordered the hit, and it's closing one of music's most infamous cold cases.*

- **Duane 'Keffe D' Davis** was convicted in the **1996 killing of Tupac Shakur**
- Shakur was gunned down in a drive-by shooting in **Las Vegas**

- The case sat unsolved for nearly **30 years** before charges were filed
- Davis, a former gang leader, admitted involvement in interviews and a memoir years before his arrest

The Debate Starter

- Does this actually feel like closure, or just one guy taking the fall for a mystery that's bigger than him?

X/Twitter @globalnews (Tier 1) | Score: 72/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 15 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://x.com/globalnews/status/2094594771389943814

■ *First-Ever US Law Cracking Down on VPNs Kicks In This Week*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): The first US law targeting VPN use taking effect on a specific date (Sept 3) lands squarely in the ongoing online privacy/censorship debate and has a clear urgency hook for tech audiences.
The Angle: *If you've ever fired up a VPN to stream something, dodge tracking, or just feel safer online, this is the first time the US has passed a law specifically going after that — and it hits right at the top of the week.*

- Reportedly the **first US law** to specifically target **VPN use**
- The law **takes effect September 3**

The Debate Starter

- Do you run a VPN daily — and does a law like this actually change what you do online?

X/Twitter @Gizmodo (Tier 1) | Score: 72/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 15 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://x.com/Gizmodo/status/2094552336517468519

■ *There's a hidden supervolcano under England?!*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): A 'hidden supervolcano discovered beneath England' is a classic surprising-science headline format that reliably outperforms its source subreddit because of its simple, startling premise.
The Angle: *Nothing says 'not today' like finding out your quiet English countryside is secretly sitting on a supervolcano — it's the kind of wild, watercooler-ready science headline that gets people googling immediately.*

- **Gizmodo** reports scientists have discovered a hidden supervolcano **buried beneath England**
- The volcano reportedly went undetected until now, hiding right under one of the most heavily-studied landscapes on Earth

The Debate Starter

- Would you still want to know if there was a sleeping supervolcano under your hometown, or is that a 'no thanks, don't tell me' situation?

X/Twitter @Gizmodo (Tier 1) | Score: 72/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 15 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://x.com/Gizmodo/status/2094525911471095972

FRANCHISE BANK

WHAT THE FRIDAY: 4 banked (+15 each when found)
- "NYC women's shelter brings cat fights, junkies and bizarre antics to neighborhood near playground https://t.co/khWuUTWRRt https://t.co/HwXL2" (X/Twitter @NYPost, banked 2026-08-13)
- "Hayden Panettiere was haunted by crippling back pain from bizarre on-set zebra accident" (nypost.com, banked 2026-08-19)
- "Abdul El-Sayed asks Fox News' Jesse Watters 'Are you circumcised?' in bizarre moment as he defends sex change surgery for minors https://t.c" (X/Twitter @NYPost, banked 2026-08-24)
- "The bizarre thing Nicole Kidman does to Sandra Bullock when she sees her" (Entertainment Weekly (via Google News), banked 2026-08-29)

THROWBACK THURSDAY: 14 banked (+15 each when found)
- ""Roseanne" Child Star Michael Fishman Slams Idea That the Show's Revival Was Unjustly Canceled: 'Words Have Consequences' - Yahoo" (PEOPLE (via NewsAPI), banked 2026-08-11)

- "Lee Daniels, Nadine Labaki, Marina Abramovic Win Liberatum Pioneer Awards (Exclusive)" (www.hollywoodreporter.com, banked 2026-08-12)
- "Chip Gaines Makes Rare Appearance with Wife Joanna on Magnolia Journal's Milestone 10th Anniversary Cover - People.com" (People (via Google News), banked 2026-08-14)
- "'Cause we (still) rock! The Jonas Brothers introduce a new generation in nostalgia-filled Camp Rock 3 (exclusive)" (Entertainment Weekly (via Google News), banked 2026-08-14)
- "Ugly inning, quiet bats doom Yankees in disappointing loss to Blue Jays" (nypost.com, banked 2026-08-14)
- "JENNIE hears the BLINKs, and now, she's sharing regrets from her heart after fans expressed they were feeling let down by the lack of celebr" (X/Twitter @Billboard, banked 2026-08-17)
- "Vin Diesel and Meadow Walker arrive to "The Fast and the Furious" 25th Anniversary Screening in LA https://t.co/zDNowKjfdg" (X/Twitter @Variety, banked 2026-08-17)
- "JENNIE Offers Heartfelt Apology After Fans Felt 'Disappointed' by BLACKPINK's 10th Anniversary" (X/Twitter @Billboard, banked 2026-08-18)
- "Pokémon 30th Anniversary TCG Set Might Feature Rarest Mew Ever - Kotaku" (Kotaku (via NewsAPI), banked 2026-08-21)
- "Sonic the Hedgehog to Headline Fortnite's 'Override' Season (Gaming News Roundup)" (variety.com, banked 2026-08-22)
- "Ranch Ehrlo Society celebrates milestone anniversary with powwow" (CTV News (via Google News), banked 2026-08-28)
- "Beyoncé Details Expansive, 27-Track 20th Anniversary 'B'Day' Deluxe Edition Featuring B-Sides, Spanish-Language Versions" (X/Twitter @Billboard, banked 2026-08-28)
- "'A modern Dickie Dee bike': Sask. boy serves up sweet treats with a side of nostalgia https://t.co/tiDR4cbOP1" (X/Twitter @CTVNews, banked 2026-08-30)
- "9/11 cancers skyrocket nearly 1,700% as toxic toll on survivors surpasses first responders ahead of 25th anniversary https://t.co/HWOFfTeKZb" (X/Twitter @NYPost, banked 2026-08-31)

SOURCES SKIPPED THIS RUN:

- r/upliftingnews (fetch failed or rate-limited)
- r/entertainment (fetch failed or rate-limited)
- www.dailymail.co.uk (fetch failed)
- @WomenBeingAwful (fetch failed)
- @EdNewtonRex (fetch failed)
- @CBCNews (fetch failed)
- @globalnews (no posts cleared the 30+ likes bar - 5 below-bar candidate(s) considered for breakout potential)
- @Gizmodo (no posts cleared the 30+ likes bar - 5 below-bar candidate(s) considered for breakout potential)
- Morning Brew (OpenCLI browser-scrape returned nothing - check Chrome/bridge)

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